ChatGPT

Cute Items Trending in 2024–2025

Plushies and Stuffed Toys

Plush toys have exploded beyond the kids' aisle – teens and young adults now proudly collect and cuddle them [1]. Social media-fueled fads turned certain plushies into must-have icons, and manufacturers responded with ever-softer, squishier designs. Key trends include eco-friendly materials (recycled or organic) for sustainability, ultra-squishy "marshmallow" textures, and even tech-enhanced plush with lights or sounds [2] [3]. The plushie scene in 2024–25 is all about comfort *and* personal style, blending nostalgia with modern aesthetics.

- **Squishmallows:** These marshmallow-soft pillow plushies remain wildly popular – traded, "squish-hunted" in stores, and showcased on TikTok. Squishmallows' collectible nature (with hundreds of characters) has driven viral frenzy similar to past toy crazes [4]. Many 20-somethings embrace them for stress relief and room décor, often amassing squads of cute frogs, cows, or fantasy creatures.
- **Jellycat & Designer Plush:** Premium kawaii plush brands like Jellycat have a cult following in the 15–30 demographic. Their whimsical designs (think *Ricky Rain Frog* or a plush baguette) often sell out quickly. Classic **Jellycat bunnies** and their novelty food series (amuseable avocados, bubble tea plush, etc.) are Instagram staples, proving that *"cute"* and *"trendy"* go hand in hand [4].
- **Sanrio and Kawaii Characters:** Iconic kawaii characters are evergreen favorites. Fans flock to buy **Hello Kitty**, **Cinnamoroll**, **Kuromi**, and **Pompompurin** plushies, especially limited editions or seasonal themes. In 2024, Sanrio released **Spring pastel bunny** plush collections for Easter and collabs like Hangyodon × Myaku Myaku (Osaka Expo mascot) that sold out fast in Japan [5]. Young adults proudly display *"shrine"* shelves of their favorite characters (My Melody, anyone?) as part of room aesthetics – proving you're never too old for cute comfort [6].
- **Anime & Game Plushies:** Popular anime, game, and pop-culture franchises feed the plush craze. **Pokémon plushies** (from Pikachu to the latest creatures) remain best-sellers worldwide. Anime fans chase limited plush from series like *Spy x Family* (Anya's chimera toy), *Demon Slayer*, or *Studio Ghibli* (Totoro and Jiji cat plush). Even indie game characters like *Animal Crossing* villagers and *Undertale* characters have spawned viral plushies. The crossover of fandom and kawaii style means even spooky or edgy characters get adorable plush forms for fans to hug.

Keychains & Charms

Tiny plush keychains and charms are the accessory of the moment, dangling from teens' backpacks, purses, and keys. Once a niche, these pocket-sized cuties have boomed *globally* as a full-blown trend [7]. They blend collectible fandom with personal flair – turning any bag into a statement of kawaii style. Many keychains double as mini plush toys, letting fans take their favorite characters on the go.

- **Mini Plush Bag Charms:** Clip-on plushies (around 3–4 inches) are hugely popular. Brands like Squishmallows introduced 3.5″ *"Clip"* versions of their characters, perfect for hanging on bags. These mini clips are *"not just cute but super practical,"* easily attaching to backpacks and featuring vibrant colors and soft textures [8]. In early 2024, a Squishmallows Easter clip set of six (bunny, chick, frog, etc.) went viral, with fans racing to decorate their bags for spring [9] [8].
- **Character Keychains:** Beloved characters in keychain form are everywhere. Disney Japan puts out seasonal **plush key holders** – for example, a line of Disney characters as sushi rolls (the plush **Donald Duck sushi** charm in the image above is a fan-favorite) [10]. Anime and game merch are big too: Studio Ghibli's fluffy **Soot Sprite** ball charm is a hit among Ghibli fans (cute, recognizable, and fits any bag) [11]. Pokémon Center sells all the **Eevee evolutions** and more as fuzzy keychain plushies, catering to the *"gotta catch 'em all"* collector mentality [12]. From Sanrio's Hello Kitty to BT21 K-pop characters, just about every fandom icon now comes in a dangly, chibi charm format.
- **Viral & Limited Keyrings:** The hype around blind-box keychains has also spiked thanks to social media. Pop Mart's **Labubu "Exciting Macaron" keyring series** (a pastel monster character) became a TikTok sensation – within weeks, Labubu key charms were dangling from designer purses and flooding unboxing videos [13]. These limited-edition blind box keychains drove collectors into a frenzy (some rare ones reselling for steep prices). The trend shows how even an obscure cute character can become a global *"must-have"* micro-accessory when boosted by TikTok hype. Luxury meets kawaii: even Blackpink's Lisa casually posed with a Labubu plush on her handbag, making it *fashion* [14]. In short, clipping a cute charm to your bag in 2024–25 is practically a lifestyle.

Stationery & Journaling Supplies

Cute stationery has become a huge trend, turning desks and study areas into pastel wonderlands. Companies are releasing whole stationery sets themed around popular characters and aesthetics. From notebooks and pens to stickers and pencil cases, these supplies prove that functional can be adorable. The back-to-school 2024 season saw a flood of kawaii stationery **sets featuring Sanrio, anime, and cartoon favorites**, appealing to students and working adults alike [15].

- **Themed Stationery Sets:** It's now easy to buy a coordinated stationery kit loaded with cute goodies. For example, **Hello Kitty & Friends** sets come with Hello Kitty notebooks, Little Twin Stars pencils, Badtz-Maru erasers, My Melody stickers, and more – all packaged in a clear pastel pouch [15]. License holders like Blueprint partner with characters from Pokémon to Pusheen to create these bundles, which have multiple items and often a matching case. Such sets are hugely popular in the UK, US, and Asia, often selling out during school season.
- **Pastel & Aesthetic Supplies:** Beyond characters, certain aesthetics dominate stationery trends. **Cottagecore** and nature themes (mushroom or floral-pattern notebooks, earthy toned washi tapes) are loved by journalers. **Pastel and Y2K** vibes show up in iridescent gel pens, sparkly sticker sheets, and translucent binders. Even mainstream brands like Zebra and Pilot have released color-themed pen bundles (e.g. all lavender or mint-green stationery kits) to capitalize on the aesthetic journaling craze [16].
- **Global Kawaii Brands:** Japanese and Korean stationery brands remain trendsetters. Fans import **Sumikko Gurashi** pencil sets and **Molang** memo pads for their irresistibly cute designs. (Notably, Plaza Japan offered a *"Go! Go! School!" Sumikko Gurashi set* packing 12 pencils, notepads, and more – a rarity since Japanese brands seldom package sets [17].) Indie kawaii brands like **Anirollz** (famous for their food-wrapped animal characters) now make notebooks, planners and even collab items (e.g. Molang bunny sticky notes) to meet demand [18]. The result: fans mix and match items to create their perfect desk setup.
- **Everyday to Premium:** There's something for every budget. Even fast-fashion retailers and toy stores carry cute stationery – in 2024, Claire's (UK) offered an affordable range of kawaii stationery

sets under £10, including *"Chibi Critters"* animal-themed kits and mini sets tucked in plush zip-up pouches [19]. On the higher end, specialty shops and online Etsy sellers offer handmade bullet journal stickers, calligraphy pens in pastel barrels, and leather planners embossed with anime characters. Whether you're bullet journaling, writing pen-pal letters, or just taking notes in class, doing it with adorable stationery has become the norm for Gen Z.

Fashion & Accessories

Cute culture has infiltrated fashion accessories too – especially with a nostalgia-driven Y2K revival. Young people are personalizing their everyday looks with whimsical, colorful add-ons that channel early 2000s vibes and modern kawaii flair. The result is a mix of playful and stylish that resonates on social media and IRL.

- **Phone Charms Revival:** The early-2000s phone charm is *back* and bigger than ever. Beaded phone straps adorned with smiley faces, hearts, and mini figures are trending globally, thanks in part to celebrities and influencers. Stars like Gigi Hadid and others have been spotted with dangly charms, helping drive this craze *"through the roof,"* as one charm shop owner noted [20]. People love that charms let them bedazzle otherwise plain smartphones – adding a personal, nostalgic touch in an age when most phones look identical. Many makers offer custom name bead charms or aesthetic-themed ones (cottagecore mushrooms, galaxy stars, etc.), with popular motifs including butterflies, letter beads, and hello kitty miniatures. Teens trade and collect these just like keychains, and some even attach multiple charms for maximum Y2K energy.
- **Kitsch Hair Clips & Jewelry:** Y2K and kawaii aesthetics have also brought back playful hair and jewelry trends. Think **butterfly hair clips**, fluffy scrunchies, and snap barrettes with cute icons (flowers, cherries, teddy bears) – a staple of the late '90s/00s now seen in TikTok fashion videos. Jewelry is similarly bright and chunky: beaded necklaces and bracelets with pastel hearts or Sanrio charms, candy-colored acrylic rings, and even DIY clay bead chokers are popular among the 15–30 crowd. These accessories embody a *"Cuteness as self-expression"* ethos, often paired with streetwear or cottagecore outfits to add a pop of whimsy.
- **Character-Themed Apparel & More:** Collaborations are churning out everything from **plush backpacks** to **kawaii sneakers**. For example, Loungefly's mini backpacks with My Melody or Pokémon designs are hot collectibles, merging fashion with fandom. Apparel lines inspired by anime and Sanrio (like Kuromi hoodies, Aggretsuko socks) fly off shelves at retailers like Uniqlo and Hot Topic. Even high fashion dipped into cute culture: in 2024, a luxury brand partnered with Sanrio for a capsule of purses and jewelry, underscoring kawaii's broad appeal. And it's not just girls – many guys in this demographic sport cute accessories too (a subtle Gudetama keychain or a One Piece anime bucket hat) as embracing "soft" aesthetics becomes more gender-neutral. In summary, cute accessories – from phones to hair to clothes – are now key to a trendy outfit, giving cheerful vibes that break the monotony of minimalist fashion.

Collectibles & Figurines

Collectible cute figures are having a major moment, blurring the line between toys and art. Mystery blind-boxes, designer vinyl figures, and capsule collectibles (gachapon) have surged in popularity, especially

within the 15–30 age group that craves both nostalgia and novelty. Fueled by unboxing videos and display-worthy designs, these mini collectibles often become viral obsessions.

- **Blind-Box Art Toys:** Leading the pack is **POP MART**, the Chinese art toy brand behind many of today's cute icons. POP MART's figurines (usually ~3-4 inches tall) come in mystery boxes, turning each purchase into a surprise. Series like *"The Monsters" Labubu*, **Molly**, **Pucky**, and **Skullpanda** have hardcore followings. The *Labubu* phenomenon in particular exemplifies this trend: by 2025, Labubu graduated from niche character to *"cultural phenomenon"* thanks to TikTok hype and FOMO-fueled drops [21] [22]. Pop Mart's revenue doubled in 2024 to $1.8 billion, with Labubu plush and figure sales spiking 1200% as collectors scrambled for limited editions [23]. Fans line up for in-store release "drops" and trade duplicates online, much like sneaker culture. It's not unusual for rare variants to resell for hundreds of dollars. In essence, blind-box toys have made collecting *cute figures* a thrilling (and sometimes pricey) hobby for young adults around the globe.
- **Sonny Angels & Mini Figures:** Before the blind-box craze, there were **Sonny Angels** – those tiny winged baby figurines wearing funny hats. Originally from Japan, Sonny Angels had a *resurgence in 2024*, tapping into collectors' love for all things retro and adorable [24]. Their soft pastel designs (fruits, animals, seasonal costumes) sparked a wave of *"cute-core"* content on Instagram. Many 20-somethings display shelves of Sonny Angels like a tiny art exhibit, or use them as props in photos. Following suit, other mini figure series (Re-Ment's miniature foods and room sets, Tokidoki's unicornos, etc.) remain popular for desk decor and flatlay photography. The key is that each piece is affordable and surprise-packed, making it easy to get hooked.
- **Anime & Pop Culture Figurines:** The love of cute collectibles extends to mainstream fandoms as well. **Funko Pop** vinyl figures – while more chibi-stylized than traditionally "kawaii" – are collected en masse by this demographic, especially when they depict anime, Marvel, or video game characters. Japanese **Nendoroid** figures (chibi, posable characters from popular anime/games) are another favorite, since they combine cuteness with customization (swappable faces/accessories). In 2024, Good Smile Company released Nendoroids for hit series like *Chainsaw Man* and *Jujutsu Kaisen*, which swiftly sold out. **Kawaii designer figs**: Independent artists also produce limited-run resin or vinyl figures (like cute ghosts, cats, or food with faces) that get hyped on platforms like Kickstarter and Instagram. Collectors enjoy supporting these artists and showing off unique pieces. Essentially, whether it's a blind-box Dunny, a Pokémon model kit, or a hand-made cottagecore figurine, if it's small, cute, and collectible, it's trending. The collector community (often overlapping with art toy and anime communities) eagerly shares display case photos and unboxing reactions, fueling even more interest in these adorable artifacts.

Digital Delights: Wallpapers & Backgrounds

In the digital realm, cute aesthetics reign supreme on device screens. Over 2024–2025, certain wallpaper themes went viral as young people curated their phone and laptop backgrounds to reflect their favorite vibes. These digital goods are often free or fan-made, spreading quickly through Pinterest, TikTok, and aesthetic blogs.

- **Cottagecore & Nature Wallpapers:** The *cottagecore* aesthetic – think cozy forests, wildflowers, and vintage charm – has inspired countless wallpapers. Youths gravitate to calming nature scenes and soft pastel art that make their devices feel like a tranquil escape. Collections of **cottagecore wallpapers** (featuring florals, woodland animals, rustic cottages) are widely shared on apps like Lemon8 and Pinterest [25] [26]. As one post noted, these images help *"create a space that invites you to*

slow down, appreciate nature… and blend creativity with comfort." [26] Many incorporate inspirational quotes in curly fonts or references to feel-good media (like Studio Ghibli films or the cartoon *Over the Garden Wall* which perfectly matches cottagecore vibes [27]). Popular motifs include mushrooms, tea parties in gardens, and warm farmhouse interiors – all tinted in gentle, dreamy hues to give that idyllic countryside feel on your lock screen.

- **Kawaii & Pastel Themes:** For those into classic kawaii or Y2K styles, there's a wealth of **cute pastel wallpapers** trending too. Sanrio characters (Hello Kitty, Little Twin Stars, etc.) in pastel scenes are perennial favorites – e.g. a pastel pink wallpaper of Kuromi holding a heart, or Cinnamoroll flying among clouds. Fans also loved **Y2K retro** designs making a comeback: pixel art hearts, 2000s-era anime screenshots with sparkles, or collage wallpapers of items like flip phones, Tamagotchis, and butterflies. These give a fun nostalgic vibe to modern devices. Additionally, "*minimalist kawaii*" became a mini-trend: solid pastel backdrops with a small cute face or icon (like a single Pusheen cat doodle) for a cleaner look. Seasonal wallpapers (spring sakura blossoms, Halloween ghost characters, holiday Snoopy or Rilakkuma scenes) go viral each year as well, letting people refresh their home screens for every occasion.
- **Fan Art & Gaming Backgrounds:** Many in the 15–30 group also use wallpapers from their favorite media. Anime scenery wallpapers – such as a still of the evening sky from *Your Name*, or a cozy ramen shop from *Spirited Away* – bring animated worlds to life on screen. Gaming-related backgrounds are popular too: from the soothing island vistas of *Animal Crossing: New Horizons* to cute indie game art (like *Stardew Valley* farms or *Minecraft* cottage builds). Often, digital artists on platforms like DeviantArt or Twitter create phone wallpaper packs themed around shows/games (e.g. a set of pastel **Genshin Impact chibi character wallpapers**), which get shared in fandom circles. The result is that one scroll through TikTok or Pinterest will reveal a plethora of *"wallpaper dump"* videos/posts, ensuring that anyone can deck out their devices with the cutest, trendiest digital art of the moment.

Digital Stickers & Emotes

Just as physical stickers and pins decorate our world, digital stickers and emotes decorate our online life. In 2024–2025, there's a huge demand for cute, expressive stickers – whether used in messaging apps, social media stories, or as virtual goods in gaming chats. Both **physical** and **digital** stickers have their place, with the kawaii aesthetic a common thread in what's popular.

- **Kawaii Sticker Packs:** The Japanese *kawaii* style has become a **global phenomenon in sticker design** [28]. Everything from chubby Shiba Inu dogs drinking boba (like the *"Boba Inu"* sticker sheet pictured) to adorable bunnies and bears are being turned into sticker sets. Small businesses on Etsy and big brands alike are embracing these exaggerated cute characters (big eyes, round bodies) to create sticker sheets that appeal to teens and young adults [28] [29]. Not only do they adorn laptops, water bottles, and notebooks in real life, but digital versions are used in planners and scrapbooking apps. In the planner community especially, **kawaii planner stickers** (for tracking habits, moods, etc. with a cute twist) are a massive trend [30]. Western designers are even blending kawaii with local influences to make hybrid styles, ensuring the *"cute factor"* resonates across cultures [31].
- **Retro, Pastel & Holographic:** Certain sticker design trends also echo in popularity. **Retro revival** stickers, featuring '90s anime style or vintage cartoon motifs, tug at nostalgia (Sailor Moon, old Pokémon art, etc.). Holographic and glitter stickers – once Lisa Frank staples – are back, adding rainbow shimmer to everything from star-shaped stickers to unicorns. Designers note that holographic finishes give a *"futuristic feel"* and instantly make a sticker feel premium and eye-catching [32]. Many popular sticker packs in 2025 mix these trends: for instance, a pack of pastel Y2K hearts with holographic sheen, or hand-drawn Tamagotchi pets with a retro filter. The physical sticker market is thriving alongside digital; as one industry blog observed, despite the hype around digital messaging stickers, people still *love* tangible stickers as a form of personal expression and collectible art [33].
- **Messaging App Stickers:** On the digital side, cute stickers for messaging apps (like WhatsApp, Telegram, LINE, and iMessage) are hugely popular. LINE in particular (widely used in Japan and beyond) releases **official sticker sets** for characters like Rilakkuma, Snoopy, and BT21, which often become top sellers. In the West, users download packs of animated cat memes, chubby panda stickers (the **"Milk and Mocha"** bear duo is a hit), and gaming-themed emotes to spice up their chats. WhatsApp introduced large sticker support, and suddenly friend groups were flooding chats with Pepe frogs in cute costumes or Sanrio emoji stickers. The **iOS iMessage Sticker Store** also saw an influx of indie creators selling cute sticker packs – from cottagecore floral stickers to pixel-art pets – proving that demand for adorable digital stickers is high. Apple even added a one-tap "make sticker from photo" feature, leading people to create their own custom kawaii stickers (often featuring their pets or favorite anime screenshots with sparkles).
- **Emotes and Emoji Culture:** In gaming and streaming communities, custom **emotes** are a big part of communication. On Twitch and Discord, users use packs of custom-created emotes – often little cartoon faces or mascots – to react in chats. Many of the most-used Twitch emotes in 2024–25 are cute or funny animals (like the famous **"catJAM"** bobbing cat or various Pepe the frog variants made kawaii). Discord servers frequently enable entire sets of anime girl chibi emotes or silly blob characters to give their community a unique identity. The **Discord emoji servers** trend (dedicated servers just to host tons of custom emotes) took off, indicating how much teens value expressive, cute visuals in online conversation. According to one list of popular emoji in 2024, classic favorites like the and ❤️ were ubiquitous, but custom cute emojis – hearts with sparkles, pouty kawaii faces – were flooding platforms where custom uploads are allowed [34]. Essentially, the way one might put an adorable sticker on a notebook, today people plaster their digital messages with stickers and emotes to convey mood and personality instantly. The aesthetics range from pastel pixel art to

meme-ish doodles, but if it's cute or evokes an "aww," it's sure to thrive in the current sticker/emote climate.

In summary, whether it's **plushies on your bed, charms on your bag, art toys on your shelf, or stickers on your laptop and phone**, *cute stuff* is an inescapable and delightful part of 2024–2025 pop culture. The 15–30 age group is unabashedly leaning into kawaii, embracing everything from Sanrio sweetness to anime flair, cottagecore calm to Y2K sparkle. These trends aren't just child's play – they're key to the vibes and community culture of a generation that finds joy and identity in all things cute [6] [30]. As social media continues to amplify viral faves (one plushie or collectible drop at a time), the global kawaii economy is booming. If it's adorable, aesthetically pleasing, and shareable, chances are it's trending right now – and bringing a bit more charm and cheer to everyday life.

Sources: The trends and examples above are backed by reports and features from 2024–2025. Key references include industry analyses of plush toy popularity [1] [4], viral trend case studies like the Labubu phenomenon [23], kawaii culture blogs and news (Super Cute Kawaii, Sticker Mule, etc.) highlighting popular products [15] [28], and firsthand observations from retailers and creators on the resurgence of Y2K accessories [20]. These sources collectively capture how and why these cute items have captivated a global audience. Each citation in the text points to the specific source for that information, for those who want to explore further. Enjoy surrounding yourself with these cute trends – after all, *we could all use a little extra cuteness!* [6] [31]

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